

does not agree with the rest of the Bible. To serve God is not vanity, salvation in Christ is not vanity, and so on. Indeed, Solomon declares openly how the book came to be: “I set my heart to seek and search out by wisdom” (1:13), “I communed with my heart” (1:16), “I set my heart to know wisdom and to know madness and folly” (1:17), “I searched in my heart how to gratify my flesh” (2:3). The book is clearly an attempt to understand life and the world using a purely humanistic analysis, leaving the Sovereign Creator out of the picture. That analysis was undertaken by a man who was very intelligent. I take it that the book was included in the Canon precisely to show to what conclusion a purely humanistic analysis of life must arrive—to emptiness and despair. However, the author concluded the book by stating the true truth, so no one would be deceived: “Let us hear the conclusion of the whole matter: Fear God and keep His commandments, for this is man’s all. For God will bring every work into judgment, including every secret thing, whether good or evil.”

Illumination

I submit that it is important that we distinguish between inspiration and illumination, with reference to Scripture. Inspiration refers to the writing of biblical material; illumination refers to the interpretation of biblical material. Both of them, inspiration and illumination, are the work of the Holy Spirit. Illumination is usually reserved for those who have been regenerated. “Now a soulish man does not receive the things of the Spirit of God, for they are foolishness to him; indeed, he cannot understand them, because they are spiritually discerned” (1 Corinthians 2:14). That is what the Text says. A ‘soulish’ person cannot understand spiritual things, which sounds rather like a congenital defect. The concrete facts contained in an historical record can be understood by anyone. That David killed Goliath is a fact that anyone can understand. But to understand the Holy Spirit’s purpose behind an inspired statement depends on illumination, and to receive it one must be spiritual (1 Corinthians 2:15).

The Canon

I now come to the question of the canonicity of the Sacred Text: why does our Bible have the exact assortment of books that it has—no more, no less, and no others? Inspiration refers to divine activity in the act of writing the material, guaranteeing the result. In contrast, the canonizing of the Text refers to human activity, recognizing the divine quality of that material. The process of that recognition took place within the community of the Faith—the Hebrew community, for the OT, and the Christian community, for the NT. I have already referred to the attitude that the Lord Jesus Christ demonstrated with regard to the OT, which was all of the